

bishers and recyclers are required to register on a portal developed by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB). This helps ensure that e-waste is managed by authorised and regulated entities. The industry believes this new regime might lead to better, more formal recycling practices, and decrease the amount of e-waste handled informally as manufacturers and producers of electronic goods would now be responsible for efficient disposal. Penalties for non-compliance, including fines and imprisonment, are expected to deter producers from dodging their responsibilities and encourage them to participate in the management of e-waste.

Secondly, producers of the newly included electronic and electrical equipment (EEE) have been assigned annual recycling targets. “These may be based on waste generation from previously sold EEE or on sales of EEE, as the case may be. The target is set to incrementally increase from 60 per cent of their end of life as specified by CPCB for the years 2023-24 and 2024-25 to 80 per cent for 2027-28 and 2028-29,” explains Kalia.

The government has also introduced a new provision for the generation and transaction of EPR certificates, under which the quantity recycled will be computed based on end products to avoid any false claims. To make this process foolproof, the government plans to introduce provisions for environmental compensation and verification and audit.

WEALTH FROM WASTE

In addition to curtailing informal e-waste practices and preventing the introduction of hazardous substances into the environment, the adoption of scientific recycling methods offers the opportunity to



“While the shift towards clean energy through solar power is highly desirable, it is crucial to have a mechanism in place for responsibly managing the resulting waste from solar panels”

RADHIKA KALIA
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
RLG SYSTEMS INDIA



“While it’s (responsible e-waste management) a good move by the government, there is scope for improvement”

NITIN GUPTA
FOUNDER & CEO, ATTERO
RECYCLING

recover valuable metals like copper, aluminium, iron, gold, silver, and nickel. E-waste contains 17 precious metals, which can be extracted through proper recycling. However, currently, only 15-17 per cent of e-waste undergoes formal recycling. By employing scientific techniques, it is possible to obtain pure precious metals and reintegrate them into a circular ecosystem. These metals can then be utilised by industries, fostering self-reliance in the procurement of critical metals, as explained by Gupta.

The rules also mandate that every producer of EEE and their components shall ensure their products do not contain lead, mercury, and other hazardous substances beyond the maximum prescribed concentration. These measures aim to ensure that manufacturers participate in and comply with managing products’ end-of-life stages.

With the new policy, India has raised its bar. Ram of CyberMedia Research says this approach is in line with international practices that emphasise the responsibility of producers in managing the environmental impact of their products. As the implementation of the new rules commenced in April 2023, Neeladri of Cerebra Green believes that in the short term, the country will see an upsurge in re-marketing/refurbishment of electronic products. The new rules will create a well-organised sector in the long term, generating revenue, employment and self-reliance for raw materials in the manufacturing sector.

Certainly, the new regulations do look good, and could help India make significant strides in sustainably managing its e-waste. The devil now lies in the implementation. **BT**

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